



T-6 Texan



B-25 Mitchell



P-51 Mustang



F-86 Sabre

1928 North American Aviation is founded by Clement Keys as an aviation holding company, based in Delaware, USA.
1935 NAA moves to Mines Field, Los Angeles (now LAX) under James "Dutch" Kindelberger and Lee Atwood.
1938 The prototype T-6 flies. It becomes the most widely produced military trainer.
1940 The B-25 Mitchell and P-51 Mustang both fly. The combined production totals of these two aircraft types eventually exceeds 25,000.

1942 B-25Bs under the command of Jimmy Doolittle launch from the USS *Hornet* and bomb Tokyo. A Rolls-Royce Merlin is installed in a P-51, greatly improving performance.
1945 A B-25 crashes into the Empire State Building, New York.
1947 The prototype F-86 Sabre, the XP-86, takes flight.
1950 The Korean War starts. When MiG-15s appear, Sabres are rushed to Korea to counter the sweptwing Soviet fighter.

1954 NAA's chief test pilot George "Wheaties" Welch is killed when his F-100A Super Sabre crashes. The accident is traced to a design flaw, necessitating an expensive redesign.
1959 NAA chief test pilot Scott Crossfield makes the first flight with the X-15 rocket plane.
1960 Lee Atwood becomes CEO.
1962 "Dutch" Kindelberger dies.
1963 NASA test pilot Joe Walker takes an X-15 to 354,000 ft (108,000 m).

1964 The triple-sonic six-engine XB-70 Valkyrie bomber begins flight testing.
1966 A Valkyrie collides with an F-104 Starfighter and both aircraft crash.
1967 A launch pad fire kills the crew of Apollo 1; NAA is partly blamed. The company merges with Rockwell-Standard.
1973 Rockwell-Standard becomes Rockwell International.
1996 Rockwell International is bought by Boeing.
1999 Lee Atwood dies.

"Any idiot can design an airplane, but it takes a genius to design an airplane any idiot can build."

JAMES "DUTCH" KINDELBERGER



F-4 Fury

The F-4 Fury was a sweptwing fighter bomber that evolved from the F-86 Sabre.

Japan. Significantly, of the 41 US pilots who achieved "ace" status during the conflict, all but one flew Sabres.

The company followed the success of the Sabre with the F-100 Super Sabre. Although extremely fast (it was the first jet aircraft to fly supersonic in level flight) the aircraft had stability problems, and an early production model crashed on October 12, 1954, killing NAA's Chief Test Pilot George "Wheaties" Welch. After this accident and several other F-100 losses, there was a significant redesign of the fin, at a cost of several million dollars. NAA also produced probably the most remarkable research aircraft ever made—the X-15. Three of these rocket-powered airplanes were made, and one was lost in a fatal accident out of a combined total of 199 flights. The X-15 set numerous records, including an altitude flight of

354,000 ft (108,000 m) and a high-speed run of 4,519 mph (7,273 km/h). The altitude record was not broken until 2004 (by SpaceShipOne), and the speed record still stands. The data the X-15 program gathered remains the principal source of information on hypersonic flight. In the 1960s the company also built the incredible XB-70, a giant six-engine bomber that was designed to cruise at 2,284 mph (3,675 km/h) and 70,000 ft (21,336 m).

In common with many of the other giant US aviation companies of the time, NAA diversified into space and began to build rockets and missiles, including the Apollo Command/Service Module and the second stage of the Saturn V moon rocket. Unfortunately, Apollo 1 was destroyed in a launch pad fire in 1967 and the blame fell partly on NAA. The same year it merged with Rockwell-Standard to become North American Rockwell. NAA engineers continued to produce ground-breaking machines including the B-1 bomber and the Space Shuttle. In 1973 the company dropped the "North American" to become Rockwell International. It was subsumed into the giant Boeing group in 1996.